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Top Skills

Product Development
Engineering Management
Payments

Tony Howard

Former Startup CTO | Senior Director @ Visa | Payments & Fintech |
Product Development Leadership
Miami, Florida, United States

Summary

Former startup CTO and Senior Director of Product Development at Visa, with 14+ years of experience building and scaling engineering organizations that deliver mission-critical financial platforms at global scale.

As Senior Director of Product Development at Visa, I lead a 100+ person organization — spanning development, QA, architecture, and DevOps — responsible for the Visa+ real-time payments platform. The platform serves hundreds of global clients and tens of millions of registered users across multiple regions and cross-border corridors, processing billions of transactions annually at high availability at global scale. I own an eight-figure annual budget and am accountable for the full product development lifecycle, from technical roadmap through production.

Prior to this role, I served as CTO of YellowPepper (acquired by Visa in 2020), where I unified product development, operations & infrastructure, and client services under a single technology leadership function — doubling organizational headcount while driving cultural transformation, compliance, and operational maturity across all technology domains.

My background spans the full spectrum of technology leadership: hands-on software architecture, engineering management, DevOps modernization, PCI DSS and SOC 2 compliance, GenAI adoption, and executive-level strategic planning. I have led regulatory collaboration with central banks, directed M&A technical due diligence, and represented engineering in major bids and RFPs across the Americas.

Earlier in my career, I delivered defense-grade software at Lockheed Martin, giving me a foundation in high-reliability, mission-critical systems that has informed my engineering philosophy throughout my career in financial technology.

I hold an M.S. in Computer Science (Cum Laude) and a B.S. in Computer Engineering from Florida State University.

I am particularly energized by opportunities to lead large-scale engineering organizations building platforms where reliability, security, and product velocity all matter — whether in payments, fintech, enterprise technology, regulated industries, or high-growth startups where I can bring enterprise-grade discipline to an early-stage environment.

Experience

Visa

4 years 6 months

Senior Director of Product Development

November 2024 - Present (1 year 8 months)

Miami, Florida, United States

Own technical roadmap and execution strategy for the Visa+ real-time payments platform, serving hundreds of global clients and tens of millions of registered users across multiple regions and cross-border corridors at 99.99% availability.

Lead a 100+ person engineering organization (development, QA, architecture, DevOps) with an eight-figure annual budget, scaling the team 33% while sustaining delivery velocity and quality standards.

Drove GenAI adoption across Product Development, achieving ~15% measured gains in developer productivity through AI-assisted coding, code review, test generation, and documentation workflows.

Delivered major platform enhancements including cross-border capabilities, payment credential tokenization, multi-region cloud database migration, and CI/CD modernization — reducing pipeline lead time by ~25%.

Director, Chief Technology Officer (YellowPepper)

January 2022 - November 2024 (2 years 11 months)

Served as CTO of YellowPepper, a Visa subsidiary, unifying product development, operations & infrastructure, and client services under a single technology leadership function — doubling organizational headcount while driving cultural transformation, compliance, and operational maturity across all technology domains.

Led annual strategic and operational planning across all technology areas, defining initiatives, budgets, and headcount plans aligned with Visa's broader business and platform strategy.

Directed PCI DSS, SOC 2, and internal Visa audits, cybersecurity and business continuity plans across all technology domains, maintaining continuous compliance and strengthening security and risk controls. Delivered ADS 2.0, a more scalable alias directory platform improving production availability, throughput, and interoperability, deployed across multiple regions including Europe to meet data residency requirements. Collaborated directly with Peru's Central Bank to define the regulatory framework for real-time payments, subsequently leading the technical implementation of compliance controls and automated regulatory reporting. Owned recruitment strategy, vendor management, org design, and performance management across all technology functions. Led the transition and integration of YellowPepper's operations and client services functions into Visa's global organizations, maintaining continuity of operations throughout.

YellowPepper Mobile Financial Solutions

Head of Engineering

September 2016 - January 2022 (5 years 5 months)

Miami, FL

Defined engineering strategy, roadmap, and architecture in partnership with Product and executive leadership, directing multiple cross-functional teams through the full SDLC for core financial platforms across Latin America and the Caribbean.

Built and managed a ~50-person blended engineering organization (mobile, backend, full stack) across multiple countries, owning recruitment strategy, vendor selection, org design, and performance management.

Established and governed engineering standards and processes — including coding guidelines, architecture patterns, release management, production support, and technical debt strategy — while driving consistent agile practices across all teams.

Led migration of all applications to GCP with Kubernetes and Docker, improving release processes and application reliability at scale.

Launched a real-time payments backend and web portal (alias directory and payment initiation) initially in Peru with a 3-bank consortium, subsequently scaling across the region.

Delivered multiple digital banking products including a mobile travel app for a top Mexican bank, a scan-and-go mobile checkout app for the largest convenience store chain in Mexico, and a mobile credit line management app across LAC and the Caribbean.

Represented engineering in major bids and RFPs, shaping technical solutions and proposals for banking clients and partners, contributing to wins with leading financial institutions in the U.S., Brazil, and a leading Latin American airline loyalty program.

Maintained annual PCI DSS and SOC 2 compliance across all platforms by integrating security and audit controls into architecture, SDLC, and operations. Led the technical workstream for Visa's acquisition of YellowPepper, addressing due diligence questions, mitigating identified cybersecurity risks, and ensuring successful completion of the deal.

Nirvana

Consultant, Product Development

October 2020 - May 2021 (8 months)

Miami, Florida, United States

Advised a digital bank startup on establishing its product development organization, including recruiting a VP of Engineering and HR talent manager, and selecting an outsourcing partner to build the initial engineering team. Collaborated with the CEO and founder to refine product vision and translate it into technical requirements and architectural direction.

Partnered with the lead architect to define and document a cloud-native target architecture, establishing clear technical direction for subsequent development.

Led the initial outsourced engineering team, running agile ceremonies and overseeing delivery of early platform features.

YellowPepper

Senior Full Stack Developer

October 2014 - September 2016 (2 years)

Miami, Florida, United States

Architected and implemented cloud-ready microservice backends for multiple products — including closed-loop mobile payments, mobile banking, and P2P/ remittance platforms — serving native iOS and Android applications across Latin America.

Designed application security and data protection controls to meet PCI DSS requirements for storing and processing payment card data.

Integrated with major payment processors across multiple markets including Mexico, Colombia, and the Dominican Republic, tailoring flows and interfaces to each processor's specifications including ISO 8583 integrations.

Developed a web-based admin and operations portal to support configuration, reporting, and client service operations across the platform.

Supported and enhanced existing products including an SMS text banking application across Latin America and a loyalty mobile application in the US, ensuring stability and ongoing feature delivery for banking clients. Worked within an Agile environment to rapidly iterate on new features and address technical debt efficiently.

Lockheed Martin

Software Engineer

February 2011 - October 2014 (3 years 9 months)

Orlando, Florida, United States

Delivered defense-grade software for mission-critical systems at Lockheed Martin, contributing to the eCASS program across both individual contributor and technical lead capacities.

Served as technical lead for an internal R&D modernization program, leading a distributed team to refactor and modernize a legacy codebase including design and implementation of a language translation layer.

Led migration of all eCASS program codebases from 32-bit to 64-bit architecture, resolving complex serialization, interoperability, and memory layout issues to deliver a stable production-ready platform within project timelines.

Implemented front-end and back-end components for a touchscreen UI enhancing usability for fighter aircraft maintenance technicians.

Education

Florida State University

Master of Science (MS), Computer Science · (2008 - 2010)

Florida State University

Bachelor's degree, Computer Engineering · (2003 - 2008)